for the contact details of the company directors. He added that the board should take a decision about Mistry's continuation, says Mukundan.

In the meantime, the union leaders from Mithapur, the birthplace of Tata Chemicals which is today the centre of salt and soda ash production in India, rallied around Ratan. There was also the general fear that Mistry could engineer the company's severance from Tata Sons. The unions said that they had worked very closely with Ratan for many years and would not want any form of severance with the holding company. In a letter to the MD, the union, Tata Chemicals Mazdoor Sangh, both welcomed Ratan as 'Interim Chairman' and offered 'full support and cooperation'. In the meantime, the Risk Management Committee and Audit Committees expressed its view that shareholder value would be seriously eroded if Tata Chemicals broke its links with the holding company.

Before the board meeting started at Bombay House, on the insistence of Wadia, the chair of the Nomination and Remuneration Committee, the committee met. Since the board meeting was to follow, all the board members were also present. Wadia was very aggressive and egregious, recalls Mukundan. Halfway through the meeting he asked the MD to leave. When he was recalled, Wadia demanded, 'Admit that you were leading a revolt against the board.' 'No,' replied Mukundan. But he added, 'I'm willing to take future directions' from it. 'Then you would have no contacts with Tata Sons without the board knowing of it. You have to take permission [before meeting],' cautioned Wadia, Mukundan recalls.

During the meeting, Wadia pushed for the company to break with Tata Sons. 'We can use the [Tata] name as we have done historically. There is no need of a licence agreement,' he said. 'According to the licence agreement, they can withdraw it [the Tata name] at any time,' explained Mukundan. The agreement was also approved by the shareholders, the MD added.

'I have never seen animosity of this kind in a board meeting,' says Bhaskar Bhat who had joined the board of Tata Chemicals in 2015. He opposed Mistry chairing the meeting. 'I opposed Mistry chairing the meeting for four reasons. The first was that if he continued as the chairman, conflict will continue, the second was that in case there is a break with the promoter, then the withdrawal of the Tata name will cause enormous loss of shareholder value, the third was that it could lead to the termination of the BEBP Agreement [leading to the withdrawal of the right to use the Tata name] and the fourth was that the employees had joined a Tata company